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**Spotify expands
audiobooks access to
family plan members in
the US for the first time**

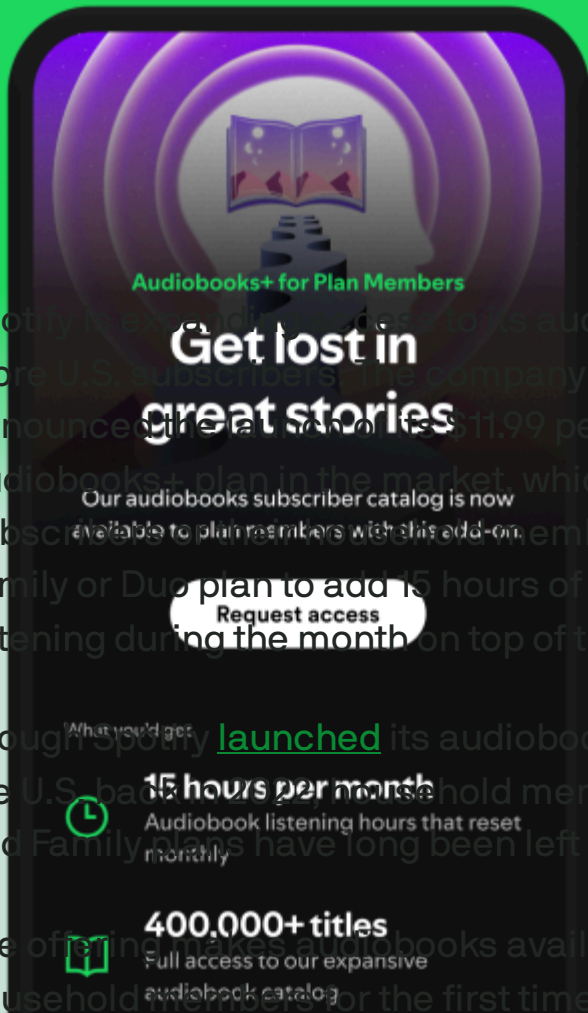


IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

Spotify has expanded its audiobooks service to more U.S. subscribers, the company on Tuesday announced the launch of its \$11.99 per month Audiobooks+ plan in the market, which allows subscribers to plan members with this add-on. Family or Duo plan to add 15 hours of audiobook listening during the month on top of the base plan.

Though Spotify **launched** its audiobooks service in the U.S., household members on Duo and Family plans have long been left out.

The offering makes audiobooks available to household members for the first time in the U.S. market.

Through Spotify Premium, subscribers already have access to 15 hours of audiobook listening per month and can buy additional hours to top off that, as needed. However, the Audiobooks+ plan gives subscribers the option to add recurring access to 15 additional hours every month, on top of the Premium plan's existing monthly allotment.

While that may be overkill for any but the more voracious audiobook listeners, the U.S. rollout of Audiobooks+ also means that other members on a subscription plan besides the cardholder can now also access Spotify's audiobooks catalog for the first time. This is made possible through the add-on called "Audiobooks+ for Plan Members."

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With the launch, the U.S. joins a handful of other markets with access to Audiobooks+, including Ireland, Canada, the U.K., Australia, New Zealand, France, Belgium, the Netherlands, Luxembourg, Germany, Austria, Switzerland, and Liechtenstein.

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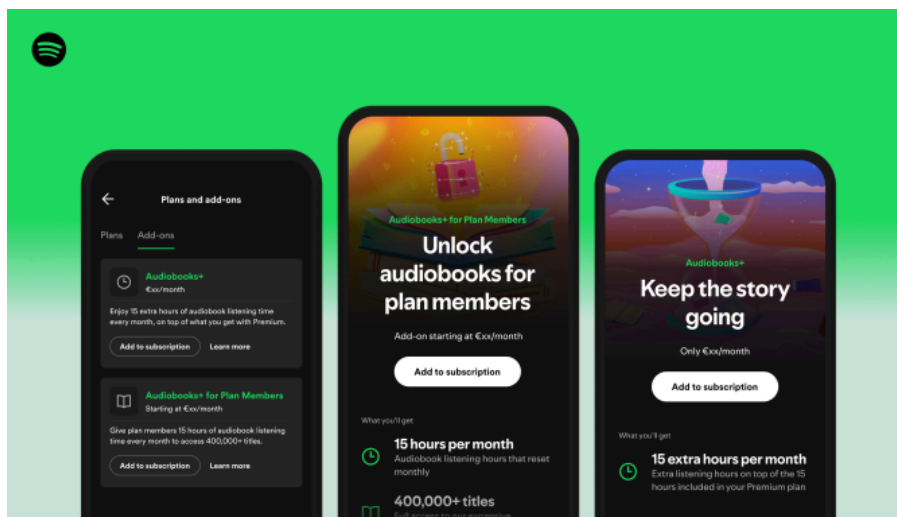


IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

The announcement of the plan's expansion to the U.S. comes shortly after a [tough quarter](#) for the streaming giant, where it missed expectations and reported weak guidance. Spotify CEO Daniel Ek pointed to a weaker ads business as the cause. (Spotify's ads chief had just left for DoorDash, media outlets reported ahead of earnings.)

Despite the loss, one bright spot for the company in the quarter was its user growth. Active users grew 11% to 696 million, and paid subscribers grew 12% to 276 million during the second quarter. The goal with the new Audiobooks+ plan is to extract more money from those existing customers.

In December, publisher HarperCollins teased a solution for the problem with household members' inability to access audiobooks. HarperCollins CEO Brian Murray said at the time that Spotify was working to adjust a "technical problem" with family plans that limited audiobook streaming only to the family plan's credit card holder.

Last month, Spotify made good on that promise when it [expanded](#) audiobook access to plan

members for the first time with the launch of Audiobooks+ in several non-U.S. markets.

Spotify doesn't share how many of its Premium subscribers stream audiobooks in addition to music or podcasts, but notes that audiobook listening hours are up more than 35% year-over-year in the U.S., U.K., and Australia. Notably, that's before these add-on plans became available.

The news of the new subscription follows Spotify's [announcement](#) on Monday that its subscription prices are increasing from €10,99 to €11,99 across markets in the Middle East, Africa, Europe, Latin America, and the Asia-Pacific region.

Spotify says it will experiment with other options for book fans in the future, including direct sales.

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor |

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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Spotify expands into the audiobooks market by partnering with Storytel

Sarah Perez — 7:45 AM PDT · May 20, 2021

Spotify is further expanding into audiobooks — but not in the way you may think. The company today [announced](#) a new partnership with audiobooks platform [Storytel](#), which will allow existing Storytel subscribers to connect their account through Spotify to access their audiobooks within Spotify's app. The partnership is the first notable example of what's possible with Spotify's recently [introduced](#) Open Access Platform (OAP), which aims to give creators and publishers a way to extend their reach.

The company briefly spoke about its plans for Open Access Platform during its press event, Stream On, earlier this year, where it also detailed plans for [paid podcast subscriptions](#), [Spotify HiFi](#) and [other new features](#). The Open Access Platform gives a publisher or creator a new way to deliver their content to their existing subscriber base by allowing their customers to stream the content through Spotify. Storytel is the first major publisher to adopt

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OAP, thought Ben Thompson of Stratechery [did say](#) that he's also using the platform.

The technology supports using the creator or publisher's existing login system and allows them to maintain direct control over their relationship with listeners. For example, a paid podcast could use the system to stream to existing subscribers. In Storytel's case, however, the company offers audiobook content, not podcasts.

"We want everyone to have access to great stories, and today Storytel offers more than 500,000 audiobooks on a global basis across 25 markets," said Jonas Tellander, Storytel founder and CEO, in the company's [announcement](#). "Partnering with Spotify make amazing audiobook experiences and exciting authorships easier than ever to access for our customers, while we will also be tapping into the opportunity of reaching new audiences who are on Spotify today, but have not yet experienced the magic of audiobooks," he added.

A competitor to Audible, Storytel offers audiobooks in a variety of languages, including some in English, for a fixed monthly price (around \$20/mo, but varies by market). Its unlimited library access may make it a better deal for people who listen to more than one audiobook per month. Typically, Storytel customers would stream via the mobile app for iOS or Android.

Spotify launches paid podcasts through new Anchor feature



Spotify today is officially rolling out paid podcast subscriptions, after first unveiling its new subscription platform at the company's "Stream On" event in February. Through Spotify's podcast creation tool Anchor, podcasters will be able to mark select episodes as subscriber-only content, then publish them to Spotify and other platforms. The service was initially tested with ... [Continue reading](#)

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The company has 1.6 million subscribers, per [a Reuters report](#). Spotify, meanwhile, has 356 million users, including 158 million subscribers across 178 markets.

The integration itself will go live later in 2021, allowing Storytel customers to sign into their accounts then stream through Spotify by linking their accounts. Spotify doesn't have plans to market to users to sign up for a Storytel subscription from its app at this time, but at the point of account

linking, users could be directed to sign up instead of log in, if need be.

Spotify had dabbled in audiobooks before Storytel. In January this year, for example, it [began testing the format](#) with a handful of classics, like “Frankenstein,” “Jane Eyre,” “Persuasion” and others, narrated by celebs. It had also previously offered the first “Harry Potter” book with chapters narrated by stars like Daniel Radcliffe, David Beckham and Dakota Fanning.

More partners for the Open Access Platform will be introduced this summer, Spotify says.

Spotify Group Session UX teardown: The fails and their fixes



We highlight some of Spotify Group Sessions user experience failings and offer ways to fix them, as well as a number of UX features that are done right.



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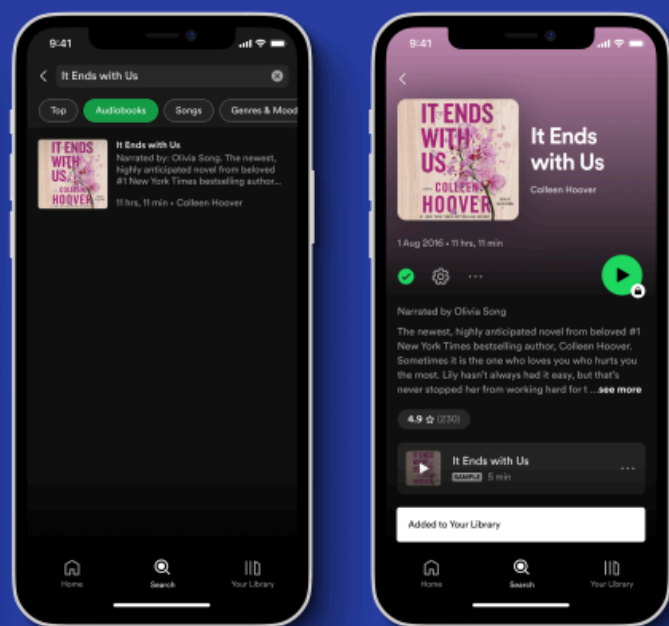


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Spotify brings 15 hours of monthly audiobook listening to Premium subscribers in the US

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its initial markets of the U.K. and Australia.

Spotify originally introduced audiobooks to its streaming music platform in September 2022,



powered browser

Ivan Mehta - 59 minutes ago

following [its acquisition of the digital audiobook distributor Findaway in 2021](#). Its debut catalog included around 300,000 titles in the U.S., then began [expanding](#) to other English-speaking markets later in the year, with the addition of [Canada in early 2023](#).

The company has touted the potential to tap into a growing market with the addition, noting that audiobooks today are only a 6% to 7% share of the wider book market, but the category was growing by 20% year-over-year. Plus, Gen Z and millennials lead consumption of audiobooks, with 72% of 18- to 34-year-olds listening.

However, accessing Spotify’s audiobooks was a cumbersome process at launch. Because Spotify didn’t want to share commissions with the app stores on in-app purchases, users would have to first purchase the titles à la carte via Spotify’s website before they could listen in-app. This introduced extra steps and made it more difficult to start listening. By bundling in a certain number of hours with its Premium subscription, the process became more seamless — now you can find the book you want and hit play to begin listening. In addition, if users want more time, they can purchase an extra 10 hours as a “top-off.”

The books themselves are discoverable through the Spotify app’s Home feed or by searching for a title. There’s also an editorially curated selection of popular titles to browse in the app’s [audiobooks hub](#).

Top titles include new releases like Britney Spears’ “The Woman in Me” and Jesmyn Ward’s “Let Us Descend,” as well as those by other popular authors, like Janet Evanovich, John Grisham, Stephen King, Colleen Hoover and others, plus musical artists like Willie Nelson and Dave Grohl. Spotify says its catalog now includes over 70% of

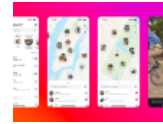
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bestselling titles, including books from the big five publishers as well as independent publishers and authors. The titles range across genres, and also include classics, like Emily Brontë’s “Wuthering Heights.”

With the addition, Spotify hopes its Premium subscription will become more compelling as it will now offer an on-demand music catalog of over 100 tracks and more than 5 million podcasts, as well as the now 200,000 audiobooks.

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In its [most recent quarter](#), Spotify grew paying subscribers by 16% year-over-year to 226 million and its monthly active users grew 26% to 574 million — 2 million ahead of the company’s forecast. Revenue was also up 11% year-over-year to €3.4 billion (\$3.63 billion USD), as Spotify benefited from recent price hikes.

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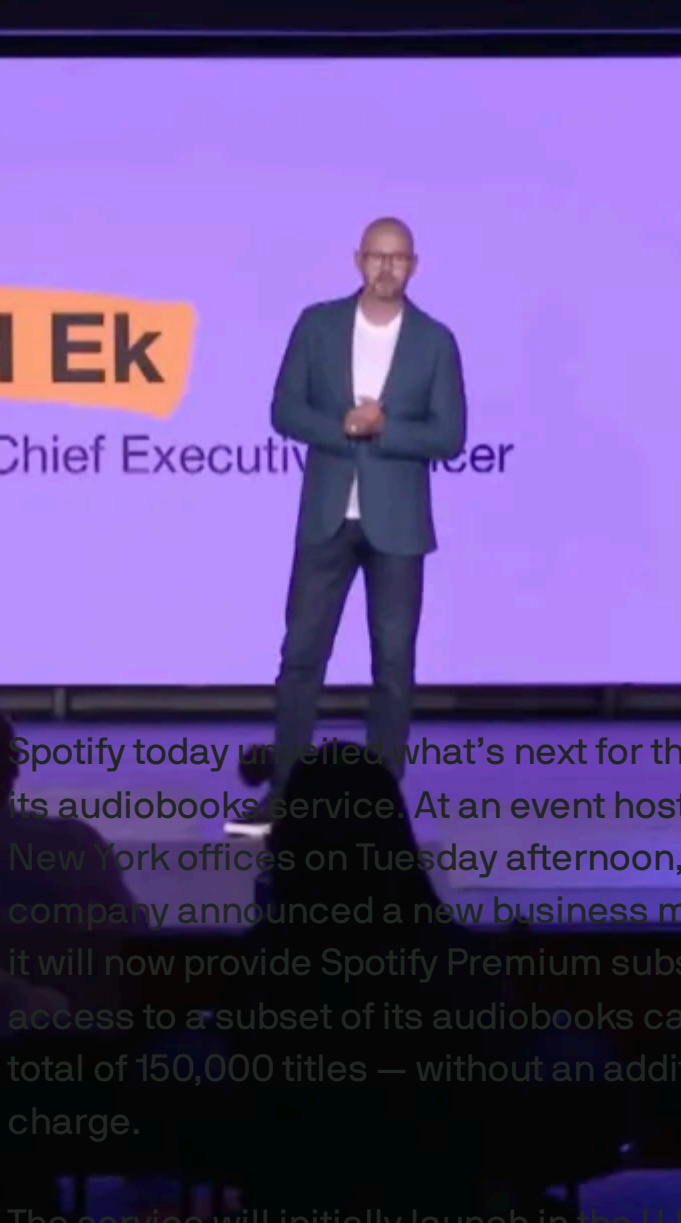
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Spotify to include a
selection of 150K



audiobooks with its Premium subscription

Sarah Perez — 1:36 PM PDT · October 3, 2023

Spotify today unveiled what's next for the future of its audiobooks service. At an event hosted in its New York offices on Tuesday afternoon, the company announced a new business model where it will now provide Spotify Premium subscribers with access to a subset of its audiobooks catalog — a total of 150,000 titles — without an additional charge.

The service will initially launch in the U.K. and Australia starting today and will launch in the U.S. later this year, with more markets to follow.

“Audiobooks today have one big dominating player. And just like in music and podcasting, we believe that many more consumers want to consume audiobooks and want to listen to audiobooks,” said Spotify founder and CEO Daniel Ek, speaking at the event. “And just like in music and podcasting, we’re really excited to be able to bring all the amazing tools that we built for creators and consumers alike to enable more discovery of these amazing audiobooks to the entire world,” he added.

Powered by its [acquisition of the digital audiobook distributor Findaway](#), Spotify first [launched audiobooks in the U.S.](#) in September 2022, with a catalog of 300,000 titles to start before [expanding to other English-speaking markets](#) later in the year

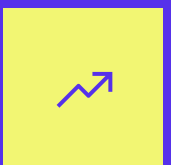
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and [Canada in early 2023](#). At the service's debut last year, Spotify touted the company's potential to tap into a growing market, noting that audiobooks were just a 6% to 7% share of the wider book market, but the category was growing by 20% year-over-year.

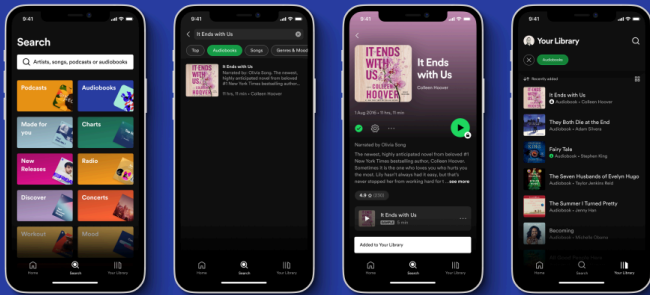


IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

However, using Spotify's service has not been as seamless as it could be for consumers because the company attempted to work around the app stores' rules regarding in-app purchases by requiring users to buy audiobooks from the Spotify website in order to play them in its app. Plus, Spotify couldn't direct customers to the website because of the app stores' "anti-steering" rules, which prevent app developers from pointing to alternative means of paying outside of the app stores' own payment mechanisms.

With access to audiobooks as part of the Premium service, listening to the books will become easier for end users.

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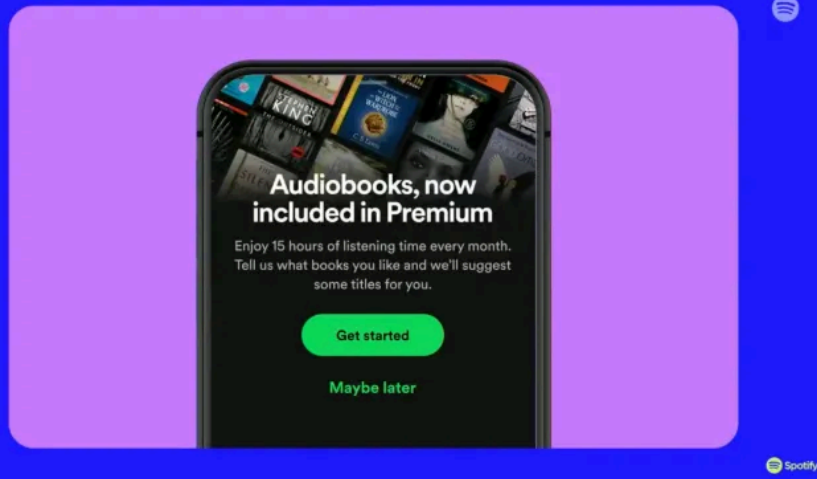


IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

Ek noted that this change will help the company by increasing user engagement with Spotify as well as reducing churn. In addition, he said it gives “great flexibility to our business which will then ultimately help our revenue and profit.”

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The company also suggested that the audiobooks market today has a distribution and discovery problem, which Spotify aims to solve the way it's done for music and podcasts.

“Tens of millions of Premium subscribers are already interested in listening to audiobooks,” said Spotify co-president and chief business officer Alex Norström. “They just need the opportunity.”

He also noted that estimates indicate that 2 billion people will read a book this year, but the audiobook slice of that pie remains small.

IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

Though Spotify's broader audiobooks catalog launched with 300,000 titles, only half of those are available through the Premium subscription. While subscribers can read as many books as they want, the service will be time-limited to 15 hours per month. But users will be able to buy more time by purchasing an additional 10 hours as a “top-off.”

Alongside the launch, Spotify will provide editorial recommendations of books to users as well as personalized suggestions based on users' tastes.

“We're going to feature editorial recommendations, curated by a diverse team of experts. And these will appear in the audiobooks hub,” explained Spotify VP,

Head of Audiobooks Business, David Kaefer. This hub will include feature shelves that highlight popular genres as well.

IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

“We’re also going to make recommendations guided by a streamlined taste onboarding,” he continued. “This is something that every listener is going to get as soon as they access their application. And it’s going to prompt users to choose some of their favorite titles and some of their favorite genres. That’s how we’re going to begin to learn how we’re going to begin to suggest the right titles to each listener,” Kaefer added.

He said tests to personalize audiobook recommendations were already underway and those will also appear in the app’s Home feed, which will put them in front of tens of millions of people daily.

Authors, meanwhile, will gain access to new tools, like promo cards they can customize with visuals, that they can use to capture users’ attention. Later, Spotify will be working on more advanced tools that will allow authors to understand how their titles are performing.

As the feature rolls out to supported markets, the available audiobooks that are included with the Premium offering will have a flag next to them so

subscribers will know they can stream the book without a charge.

Users will also be able to share their favorite audiobooks on social media with built-in sharing tools and will be able to curate audiobook playlists.

“We’ve got instant access. We’ve got discovery. We’ve got front-and-center placement, easy social amplification, and dedicated tools,” Kaefer concluded. “And all of these things are going to help increase the number of people listening to audiobooks and help listeners engage with the format with less friction,” he said.

[Spotify expands into audiobooks with acquisition of Findaway](#)

[Spotify brings audiobooks to US users with a catalog of 300,000 titles to start](#)

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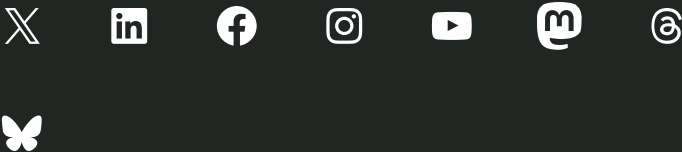
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